you from behind in order to stop you. Gary was the worst. You'd end up bruised all over, wondering what you'd done to annoy him. I dreaded those sessions then but, four years later, by the time I was lining up in the Premiership against the likes of Stuart Pearce and Julian Dicks, I was grateful that the first serious whacks I'd taken had been from my own team-mates.

It wasn't just when we were doing that particular routine that Gary and Chris Casper did their best to give me grief. Busy they were, the pair of them. Cas was very big and strong for his age. His dad, Frank, had been a player with Burnley when they were a top side in the sixties, and Chris had obviously picked up habits from him. He had this very grown up, professional attitude. And, when we were playing together, he talked non-stop through every single game. Sometimes Cas played at the back; he ended up playing center-back as a professional. Other times he'd get a game in central midfield, which meant I'd be playing alongside him. He'd be shouting encouragement, telling me who to pass to. And not just me: he'd be telling anyone within earshot. He even used to talk to himself. After ninety minutes, I'd have a splitting headache and what made it worse was that Dad thought it was good to be like that.

'You should be like Cas, you know. You should be talking like him. More than him, even.'

I'd be thinking: I prefer silence. As I've got more experienced—and especially since I've been a captain—I've come to understand how important it is to communicate on the field. Obviously you have to let a team-mate know if someone's coming to close him down but, if someone can't see a pass for himself then, by the time you've told him, the moment's probably gone anyway. If you're playing for Man United or for England, do you need your mate telling you, minute by minute, if he thinks you're playing well? Of course you have to talk. Half the time, though, I thought Cas was talking just for the sake of it. It was like lining up alongside a commentator.

He used to get on my nerves when we played together, but Cas and I were good mates too. He was one of a small group of us who went away on vacation together. My mum and dad were the first people to meet Joe Glanville: they'd always run into him at games. Joe was Maltese, and United mad. They got to know each other and, the next thing I knew, my parents were telling me we were going on vacation to Malta. Everything was being taken care of at that end and we just had to get ourselves to the airport at the right time, with our bags packed.